DRIVER A
JFK, JFK (Pulse) JFK, JFK

(Over the walkie-talkie app, drivers all talk at once in Fujian Dialect.)

INT. CAR - GOING THROUGH THE CAR WASH MACHING - DAY

Inside the car. Two phones are mounted to the right of the steering wheel: one running a walkie-talkie app (Zello), the other an encrypted group chat. The chatter mixes with the roar of the car wash outside.

White foam from outside covers the windshield, and the car interior goes dark. IVAN (46, Chinese man) checks his watch and presses the talk button.

IVAN
I can do JFK. I can do JFK.

CUT TO:

INT. AUTO REPAIR SHOP - DAY

On the counter at the car wash: a case of bottled water, a badminton bag, and a plastic bin full of odds and ends.

Ivan, with a crossbody bag across his chest and a puffy down jacket on, carries them one by one back to the trunk of his seven-seater. The car is spotless, all its doors open.

Worker A (male, asian) brushes off a passenger floor mat and puts it back. Worker B (female, asian) is hidden behind the open hood, leaning in with a flashlight, installing the insulation layer inside

IVAN
It was fine. How'd it just break?

Ivan keeps his eyes on Worker B while he talks. Worker B meets his look awkwardly, then goes back to work.

EXT. FLUSHING STREET - DAY

Ivan drives through the streets of Flushing. Suddenly his phone rings. The ringtone is an old Cantonese song.

IVAN
Hello (...) Go ahead (...) No I'm heading to JFK for a pickup, I don't have time (...) Fine, send me a list of what you want to eat.

turns into a parking lot.

INT. MALATANG RESTAURANT - DAY

Ivan glances up at the sign to make sure, then walks into the malatang place. He picks up a tray and tongs and walks along the chilled display case. Checking the list the customer sent to his phone, he picks out each item: beef tripe, instant noodles, sliced beef, sliced lamb, fish balls... He double-checks, then takes the tray to the register.

CASHIER
Soup Base?

IVAN
(checks his phone) One bowl of Sichuan insane spicy.

The bell rings at the pickup window. Ivan turns and sees red chili oil and peppers floating on a bowl of soup. He swallows. A customer hurries over and takes it.

IVAN
(to the cashier) Hold on.

INT. CAR - DAY

Through the car window, we see Ivan in the distance, jogging over with two big bowl of malatang.

He gets in, shuts the door, sets the bowls on the seat, rubs his hands, breathes into them, and starts the car.

EXT. HIGHWAY - DAY

The car weaves through highway traffic. A sign says JFK Airport is ahead. Ivan sticks a nasal inhaler up his nose and breathes in the menthol to stay awake. He checks the time on his phone, finds the airport customer's number in the drivers' group chat, and calls.

IVAN
Hello? I'm the driver picking you up. Got your bags yet?

CHAO
Just landed. Still in line at customs.

IVAN
Okay, call me when you have your bags. What's your full name?

CHAO
(pause) I need to give my name for a ride?

IVAN
Bro cops are everywhere thesedays. If one asks, just say I'm your older brother. Don't say it's a ride.

CHAO
(holding back a laugh) Oh... okay, brother. My name's Yang Chao.

IVAN
My last name's Wang. Wang Qiang. Remember that. I'll text it to you too.

Ivan hangs up, the inhaler still in his nose. He pulls the work phone running the drivers' walkie-talkie off the dash, mount and all, and hides it into the center console.

EXT. ARRIVALS, UPPER LEVEL - AFTERNOON

In the distance, a car cuts across the pickup lanes. CHAO stands with five big suitcases, holding up his phone, scanning the traffic. Ivan comes in fast and brakes hard right in front of him, hazards on. He gets out without even saying hi, goes around to open the trunk, and grabs the first suitcase. Chao freezes for a second. Ivan is already on the second one.

The third row is folded down. Ivan practically kicks the last suitcase in. Far off, an officer in a reflective vest is watching them.

Ivan shuts the trunk, gets back in the driver's seat, and opens the automatic door. Chao climbs in after him.

IVAN
Hurry up, kid. TLC's coming.

CHAO
TLC?

Ivan has just started the car when someone knocks on the passenger window. An officer in a reflective uniform and sunglasses signals for them to roll it down.

OFFICER
TLC. Hands off your steering wheel.

The officer looks inside and sees Chao.

OFFICER
You two, get out of the car. You're suspected of running an unlicensed taxi.

CHAO
He’s my cousin.

IVAN
Cousin...Brother!

OFFICER
(pause)Show me your IDs.

The two of them fumble to hand over their IDs. The officer points at Ivan.

OFFICER
What's his name?

IVAN
Yang Chao, I mean, Chao Yang.

OFFICER
What about his?

Chao freezes, names racing through his head. Then he spots Ivan's business card tucked behind the passenger headrest: QIANG WANG, LOCAL DRIVER, Tel: XXX, Email: XXX.

CHAO
...QIANG WANG!

The officer checks the IDs, still not sure, and hands them back. His radio crackles with a call from a coworker.

OFFICER
Here you go.
(into the radio) Coming.
(to Ivan) You're good to go.

INT. CAR - DAY

The officer pats the car and waves them on. Ivan gives him a faked smile. They're both still shaken. Ivan slowly pulls away, and only then closes the door and rolls up the window. The car goes quiet. They both look back. The officer is far behind them now. They finally let out a long breath.

IVAN
...That was close, kid!

Ivan pulls a pack of cigarettes from the door pocket and offers one to Chao. Chao waves it off. Ivan rolls down his window.

IVAN
Kid, out here you gotta be quick. You're the first one I've had who caught on that fast.

Ivan takes a sheet of paper out of the center console and hands it to Chao.

IVAN
Look at the number.

CHAO
...Five hundred bucks?

IVAN
Yeah, I got caught last month! Five hundred the first time, two thousand the second! Fuck!... Hey kid, you know the fare's ten bucks more today, right?

CHAO
What? the guy told me it’s 55?

IVAN
That's the normal price. TLC's been cracking down. Drivers take a risk coming out here.

CHAO
The guy who set this up didn't tell me that.

IVAN
Relax, I'm not gonna rip you off bro! Besides, how much is an Uber back? 120? This is almost half off! And let me tell you, these fucking apps are full of shit! They take half your fare and even your tips, damn it!

Ivan puts out his cigarette in an empty pack as he talks. In the back seat, Chao rolls down his window.

EXT. QUEENS HIGHWAY - LATE AFTERNOON

MONTAGE: THE CAR DRIVES DOWN THE HIGHWAY, THEN TURNS INTO LONG ISLAND CITY. IVAN PLAYS MUSIC AS HE DRIVES.

INT. CAR - LATE AFTERNOON

Ivan turns the music down, glances at Chao asleep in the back seat, and reaches back to pat his leg.

IVAN
Almost there, kid! Wake up.

Chao opens his eyes, groggy.

IVAN
(smiling) So where'd you fly in from, handsome?

CHAO
Beijing. Eighteen hours.

IVAN

So you're an international student, huh?

CHAO
Yeah.

Ivan hands Chao one of his business cards.

IVAN
Here's my card. Tell your friends about me. Good-looking guy like you, you go out much?

CHAO
Huh? No, not really.

IVAN
Next time introduce me to some girls.

CHAO
...Don't you have a wife and kids?

IVAN
Well, they are Back in China.

The car goes quiet.

EXT. BUILDING DROP-OFF - LATE AFTERNOON

The car pulls up and stops at the drop-off. Ivan and Chao get out. Chao says hi to the security guard at the door.

Ivan looks up at the building, about seventy stories tall. He goes to the back, opens the trunk, and struggles to drag the suitcases out. The guard takes a dolly over, then grabs the other end of a suitcase, and lifts it on with one hand. Ivan stands off to the side, wipes his hands on his pants, and pats his own bicep at the guard.

IVAN
(Chinglish) Strong!

Chao pulls some bills from his wallet and hands them over. Ivan takes them with both hands and nods.

INT. CAR - CONTINUOUS

Ivan gets back in the driver's seat and shuts the door. The outside noise cuts out. He stuffs the money into a bag on the passenger seat.

He looks up at the rearview mirror.

A guy in flip-flops and shorts, hair a mess, comes out of the building and runs over to high-five Chao. They high-five, one throws an arm around the other's neck, and they head inside.

Ivan lights a cigarette and drives off. It's very quiet in the car.

EXT. QUEENSBORO BRIDGE - BLUE HOUR

Ivan's car crosses the Queensboro Bridge from one end to the other.

EXT. ONE MANHATTAN SQUARE - NIGHT

Ivan's car pulls up outside One Manhattan Square, an even taller, fancier building. A young girl in sandals and a T-shirt is waiting at the door.

He parks, grabs one of the two bowls of malatang, and jogs to the door. She hands him a hundred-dollar bill.

YOUNG WOMAN
Thanks Ivan.

IVAN
Get inside, it's cold out. Don't catch a cold.

Ivan gets back in the car and keeps rubbing his hands against the cold. He holds the hundred-dollar bill up to the light with both hands to make sure it's real.

He opens the plastic bag with his own bowl, and starts eating.

Still eating, he calls Peter.

PETER
Hello?

IVAN
Hey, you done for the day? Let's go play. I'm wrapping up early.

PETER
Not driving today. I'm gambling.

IVAN
Gambling is borrowing money from the devil. Don't come crying to me when you lose it all.

PETER
I'm gonna win big today. See you at the courts at eight?

IVAN
Okay, see you soon.

After a few bites, Ivan's face turns bright red. He keeps sucking in air. The spice is killing him.

EXT. CORNER STORE - NIGHT

At the corner store across the street, Ivan grabs a bottle of milk, goes to pay, and picks up a pack of cigarettes too.

Ivan walks out of the store.

EXT. STREET NEAR THE CORNER STORE - NIGHT

Ivan drinks the milk as he walks and wipes his mouth on his sleeve. The burn is fading. His car is just around the corner. As he gets closer, he sees a parking ticket stuck right on the windshield.

Ivan hurries over, rips off the ticket, and looks around. The traffic cop is long gone.

INT. BADMINTON CLUB LOCKER ROOM - NIGHT

In the locker room, Ivan takes off his shirt, socks, and shorts, puts on workout clothes and badminton shoes, and gets ready to play.

INT. BADMINTON CLUB - NIGHT

The badminton club is huge and packed with people of every background. You can hear all kinds of languages: Burmese, Hindi, Vietnamese, Mandarin...

Ivan comes out of the locker room and walks past Courts 4 and 5, where people are shouting back and forth. He sticks to the edge, turning sideways to stay out of the players' way.

He goes to an empty chair by Court 1, says hi to three players about his age on the court, and starts warming up, watching the game on Court 2.

Suddenly a shuttlecock lands by his feet. It came from Court 5. A player over there waves sorry. Ivan grabs his racket and awkwardly hits it back.

Ivan keeps warming up, awkwardly. He bends over so far his head almost pokes through his legs, and he can see the people behind him.

CUT TO:

Ivan is playing. His form is decent, but every swing looks like it takes every muscle in his body. He looks a mess. His partner is PETER (51, Asian man, big belly). It's a doubles game, and they're keeping up with the other side point for point.

CUT TO:

Ivan rests by the court, wiping his face and armpits with a towel. Suddenly someone tosses him two energy drinks from the left. He catches them. Peter enters the frame.

Peter is holding a brand-new racket, wrapping a fresh grip on it.

Ivan takes the racket and looks it over closely.

PETER
Just bought it at the counter.

IVAN
How much did you win at the casino today?

Peter holds up two fingers.

IVAN
Two hundred?

Peter shakes his head.

IVAN
Two thousand?!

Peter nods. Ivan stops wiping his sweat.

PETER
The new casino at the Flushing stadium! Real dealers, not like that place in Queens with the machines. You can't beat a machine!

IVAN
So you're almost back to even?

PETER
Not all the way. Give me two or three more trips.

Ivan takes a sip of his energy drink and offers the other bottle to Peter. Peter waves it off and holds up a bottle of water.

PETER
Both are for you. My numbers are high again. Water only.

Peter lifts his shirt to show him the red needle marks on his body.

They go quiet. Ivan doesn't know how to comfort him.

Ivan looks over at Courts 4 and 5. They're empty now. He points his racket that way.

IVAN
Wanna play over there?

They grab the tube of shuttlecocks and their rackets and head to Court 5.

Five young people in their early twenties, guys and girls, sit on the bench by the court. They're in bright red athletic clothes, with pro racket bags at their feet. Two of them are on their phones.

Ivan gestures at them with his racket.

IVAN
Hey, guys, want to play doubles? Two on two?

They look up and glance at each other.

YOUNG PLAYER
No thanks, sir. We're tired. We're done for today.

Ivan turns back and picks a shuttlecock up off the floor.

Behind him, the young players huddle and talk quietly. We can't hear what they're saying. Ivan and Peter start playing on Court 5.

CUT TO:

INT. BADMINTON CLUB SNACK COUNTER - NIGHT

The kettle boils. Ivan picks it up and fills his cup of instant noodles. Peter has one too and is already eating next to him.

PETER
That's too much water.

Ivan goes over to the trash can to pour some out. As he pours, he sees the young players from Court 5 back on the court, running fast and hitting harder than anyone. He feels a pang, but keeps fiddling with his noodles.

EXT. BADMINTON CLUB PARKING LOT - NIGHT

Ivan comes out the side door of the club. A gust of cold wind hits him. He hunches his shoulders and jogs across the lot, pressing his key fob as he goes. The headlights flash twice.

INT. CAR - CONTINUOUS

He gets into the driver's seat, slams the door, starts the car, and turns the heat all the way up. He holds his hands up to them, rubs them together, and holds them up again.

He sniffs. Sniffs again. Frowns. He turns and leans toward the passenger seat, where the plastic bag from the afternoon's Malatang is still sitting. He picks it up, smells it, and tosses it back.

He smells his sleeve, then the steering wheel, then the headrest. Finally he puts his face up to the vent and sniffs. He jerks back and covers his nose.

EXT. BADMINTON CLUB PARKING LOT - CONTINUOUS

Ivan gets out, feels his way to the front of the car, and pops the hood. He turns on his phone's flashlight and shines it inside.

The light moves over the engine, over the brand-new white insulation put in that afternoon. There's already a fresh hole in the edge, with tiny bite marks. In the groove near the windshield sit a few brown feces of different sizes.

Nearby, the sound of a small animal scurrying.

He looks up and points the flashlight toward the sound.

The light moves over a row of parked cars.

A dark shape darts through the beam and disappears into the dark.

THE END